

officers and men, commanded by John Worden, were exhausted and hungry. Nonetheless, Worden immediately set course to attack the *Virginia*.

The two vessels closed to point-blank range and opened fire. The *Monitor*'s armor warded off the hammer blows of the *Virginia*'s guns, but the *Monitor*'s fire had no more effect on the *Virginia*'s iron plates. In cramped, fume-ridden conditions, the *Monitor*'s gunners had problems with the innovative gun turret, which eventually had to be kept in permanent rotation, firing as the guns swept across their target. In the smoke, visibility was limited for both crews, and the two ships went almost blindly around one another as they blasted away. The *Monitor* was smaller and faster and her flat bottom was an advantage in the shallow waters. At one point, the *Virginia* ran aground on shoals, but she was freed and the battle continued.